

THE END OF foot-binding

20TH-CENTURY CHINA

The spread of feminist ideas in early 20th-century China was due in part to the activities of foreign Christian missionaries, but it also sprang from a new emerging Chinese intelligentsia. Wealthy families sent their children to be educated in Europe or the US, hoping that on their return they would take up prominent positions in society. Inspired by concepts such as individual freedom, this young group began to disseminate Western ideas in China. As a result, the Chinese Nationalist Party, known as the Kuomintang, was set up in 1912 by Sun Yat-sen, the founding father of the Republic of China. This opened the way for modernization along Western lines, with a radical transformation of the state system.

Era of reform

Reform-minded intellectuals addressed women's issues such as the centuries-old custom of foot-binding. Traditionally, in China small feet represented the pinnacle of female beauty: however, foot-binding was a practice that was inextricably linked to suffering and disability. Founded in 1883, the

Anti-footbinding Society campaigned throughout China to end the painful but popular practice, and soon reached 300,000 members. Under pressure from these campaigners, the Empress Dowager Cixi issued an edict against foot-binding in 1902. Although the ban was annulled in 1912, with the fall of the Qing Dynasty, the practice was finally ended by the Republic of China in 1949. Thereafter foot-binding was seen as an outmoded symbol of China's past.

Chinese reformers also sought fundamental changes in education. Philosopher Liang Qichao, for example, argued that in order to build a strong nation, women needed to be educated and financially independent. Prior to the late Qing period, Chinese



◀ Footloose, finally

This watercolor depicts female cyclists on a street in China c.1900. Across the world women on bicycles represented that the times were changing, not least for women's clothing.

